

MATH

Placement Information

STUDENTS: LOG IN TO ALEKS

Choosing the Right Course

Social and Natural Science Majors

Most Social and Natural Science majors are required to take Statistics (MAT52-114) and/or Modern Calculus I (MAT52-164). It is extremely important to consult with your advisor before choosing your mathematics course.

Non-Science Majors

We recommend that non-Science majors take Explorations in Mathematics (MAT52-104), Statistics (MAT52-114), Modern Calculus I (MAT52-164), Explorations in Computing (54-144), and/or Computer Science I (CSC54-184).

What is the “Modern Calculus” sequence?

The Modern Calculus sequence is our replacement for the “traditional” Calculus sequence, and the two differ in a number of important ways. Modern Calculus emphasizes skills and tools that are used in the modern world. Technology is used as a tool to illuminate calculus concepts. Additionally, Modern Calculus promotes multivariable functions and multivariate reasoning throughout the sequence.

Students should note that the traditional order of topics is altered in Modern Calculus. As a result, students who have previous Calculus experience will still see new material in our Modern Calculus sequence.

Modern Calculus I or Modern Calculus II?

Students who wish to take Modern Calculus II (MAT52-264) must have a minimum of C- in Modern Calculus I (MAT52-164) or equivalent. Transfer credit for (traditional) Calculus I allows entry into Modern Calculus II without consultation. For AP credit, see below.

Exam Placement

An AP score of 4 or 5 on the Calculus AB exam yields credit for Calculus I. A student with this score will be placed in Modern Calculus 2.

An AP score of 4 or 5 on the Calculus BC exam yields credit for Calculus I and four additional math credits. A student with this score will be placed in Modern Calculus 2.

Those with AP scores of 3 should consult with a Calculus instructor to aid their placement.

ALEKS Math Knowledge Check

opportunity to improve your math skills with targeted learning.

What does my score mean?

The table below provides some guidance based on your Math Knowledge Check Score.

Score	Next steps
0-35	• Take Modern Quantitative Methods in your first year at Southwestern. • Talk to your academic advisor about what an appropriate course load might include.
36-69	• You are eligible to enroll in Modern Calculus 1 during or after Sprog Orientation. • You must work in the ALEKS PPL Learning Modules to improve your score up to 70 by July 31st. ◦ If your score is 70 or above by August 1st and you are currently enrolled in Modern Calculus 1, you will remain in the course. ◦ If your score is still between 36-69 on August 1st and you are enrolled in Modern Calculus 1, you will be removed from Modern Calculus 1. ◦ If space permits, you may be automatically added to the Modern Quantitative Methods course. Check with your academic advisor to discuss potential next steps. • Talk with your academic advisor about what an appropriate course load might include.
70-100	• You are ready for quantitative courses at Southwestern! • You can always return to ALEKS to brush

I have taken the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check - now what? How many times can I attempt ALEKS? Are there any rules around subsequent attempts?

Once you are finished with the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check, you will immediately receive your score and some information about what that score means. Everyone gets 5 total attempts over a one-year period. The ALEKS system settings (rules) behind subsequent attempts are as follows:

- You must wait 48 hours between each attempt, and...
- You must work for 3 additional hours in ALEKS before the second attempt will be available.
- You must work for 5 additional hours in ALEKS before the third, fourth, or last attempt will be available.

Do I need to take the ALEKS Placement Test if I recently took the AP Calculus exam?

If you recently took the AP Calculus AB or Calculus BC exam in the most recent Spring semester, you will not have your scores until July, which is after the Sprog Orientation. In this scenario, **YES**, you must still take the ALEKS Placement Test. If Southwestern has received an earlier score of 4 or 5 on the AP Calculus AB or Calculus BC exams, then no, you do not need to take the ALEKS Placement Test.

Are there any exceptions to taking the ALEKS Placement Test?

It is only possible to be exempted from taking ALEKS if SU has received 1) transfer credit for Calculus I, or 2) a score of 4 or 5 on the AP Calculus AB or BC exam. Students will be required to take ALEKS if Southwestern has not received the transfer credit or AP exam scores.

Do I need to take the ALEKS Placement Test if I recently took the ALEKS Placement Test at a different school?

MAYBE NOT. If you recently took the ALEKS Placement Test at a different school, you might not have to take it again. This depends on whether the school you came from is set up to send your ALEKS scores. First, you must create your Southwestern ALEKS account. Next, you must work with Dr. Tran at tranw@southwestern.edu to see if you can transfer your test scores from your previous school to your Southwestern ALEKS account.

If your previous school allows for the score transfer, you do not need to take the ALEKS Math Placement Test. If your previous school does not allow the score transfer, you must take the ALEKS Math Placement test on your Southwestern ALEKS account.

What if I'm not an incoming student but plan to take Modern Calculus I? Do I still need to take ALEKS? What if I need the support from ALEKS—is there still a way for me to enroll?

If you are not a Fall 2025 incoming student, you do not have to have an ALEKS score of 70 to enroll in Modern Calculus I. However, if you are nervous about your background or want additional support you can reach out to Dr. Will Tran ([email](#)) to learn about potential options.

Why should I take Modern Calculus I at Southwestern and not at a community college?

At SU we have a lower required ALEKS score (70) than many local community colleges. For example, Austin Community College requires an ALEKS score of 80 to enter their Calculus I course and a 65 to enter Pre-Calculus and all testing attempts (up to 5) must be done in person at a testing center.

Why should I try my best on the ALEKS Math Knowledge Check?

meetings. Some instructors may require you to work towards a particular score as part of your class.

What is Southwestern's honor code?

Southwestern's Honor Pledge: "I have acted with honesty and integrity in producing this work and am unaware of anyone who has not."

You may not use outside resources (textbooks, friends, family, search engines, online equation solvers, calculators etc.) while taking the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check. Using an unauthorized resource or cheating on the ALEKS PPL is a violation of the Southwestern University's Honor Code and may result in disciplinary action. There is no benefit to cheating on the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check – the goal is to ensure adequate preparation for your math and/or chemistry courses which can lead to success in these and future courses.

Who will be my contact person once I have completed the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check?

Your contact person will be Dr. Will Lopez Tran. You may receive email communication from Dr. Tran regarding ALEKS. If you have any questions after completing the ALEKS PPL Math Knowledge Check, you may email Dr. Tran at tranw@southwestern.edu

What if I have problems with the software while I am using it online?

Please do not write to faculty or technical support people at Southwestern with ALEKS questions. ALEKS provides excellent support for their software. See <http://support.aleks.com> .

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CONTACT